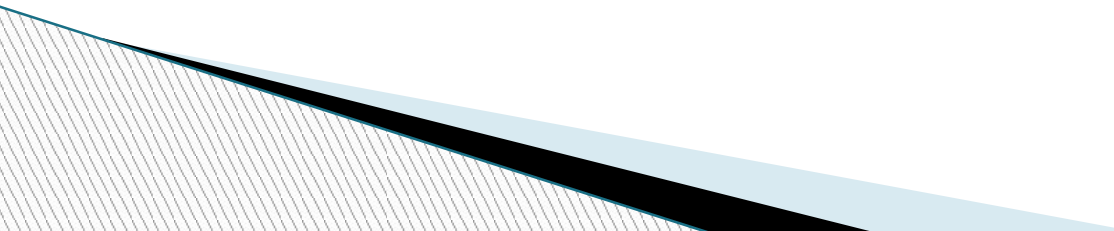


Politics of Representation of Post- Ivan Katchanovski, Ph.D. Communist Countries In American, British, and Canadian Films

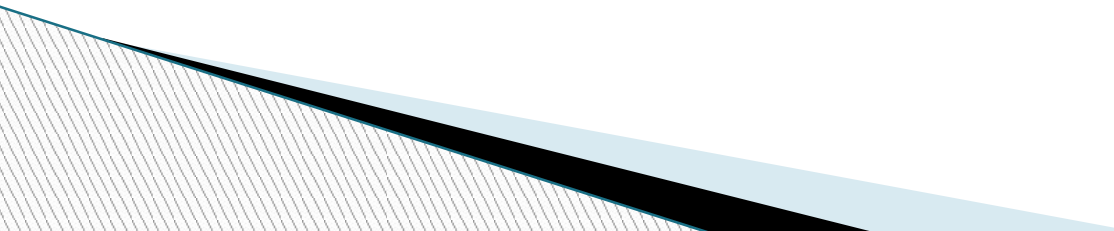
Research Questions

- ▶ The study examines the role of political factors in representation of post-communist countries in Canada, UK, and US films
 - ▶ The research questions
 - Are there significant differences in the extent and the content of depiction of East Central European and post-Soviet countries?
 - Do American films differ significantly from Canadian and British films in their portrayal of the post-communist nations?
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Previous Studies

- ▶ Lack of comparative studies
- ▶ Most focused on a single country or other time periods
 - The Soviet Union in US films
 - Poland in Hollywood films during WWII
 - Kazakhstan in *Borat*
- ▶ Political dimension/controversies
 - Slovakia in *Hostel*
 - Poland in *Defiance*
 - Kazakhstan in *Borat*
 - Russia's Putin as an elf in *Harry Potter* films?

Research Hypotheses

- ▶ Post-communist countries that are American, British, and Canadian allies receive more positive depiction compared to non-allies
 - ▶ More films and more popular ones are devoted to East Central European countries than to comparable post-Soviet states, with the exception of Russia
 - ▶ Post-Soviet countries receive more negative portrayal than East Central European countries
 - ▶ British and Canadian films, compared to Hollywood movies, offer a more balanced representation of post-communist countries
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Data and Methodology

- ▶ Comparative and content analyses of more than 250 films
 - Produced in Canada, the UK, and the US in 1992-2010
 - Grossed at least one million US dollars in 2010 prices in one of these countries
 - The films are identified with help of keyword searchers of the Internet Movie Database
 - Explicit references: place, name, language, etc.
- ▶ Content analysis of representation of post-communist *countries*
 - Positive, neutral or negative

Post-Soviet countries in American, British, and Canadian films in 1992-2010

	Population in 2009, million	Film references	Box office, million US\$
Russia	142	204	17564
Ukraine	46	27	2875
Kazakhstan	16	8	1057
Uzbekistan	28	7	830
Georgia	4	6	668
Armenia	3	7	494
Belarus	10	3	355
Azerbaijan	9	3	306
Kyrgyzstan	5	3	272
Turkmenistan	5	1	235
Tajikistan	7	2	228
Moldova	4	3	185
<i>Post-Soviet, excl. Russia</i>	137	70	7505
Post-Soviet unspecified		3	635

East Central European countries in American, British, and Canadian films in 1992-2010

	Population in 2009, million	Film references	Box office, million US\$
Czech Republic	10	18	1844
Hungary	10	24	1440
Romania	21	21	1438
Poland	38	22	1179
Slovakia	5	9	1131
Bulgaria	8	3	458
<i>East Central European</i>	93	97	7490

Representation of post-Soviet countries in American, British, and Canadian films, %

	Positive	Neutral	Negative
Russia	15	1	84
Ukraine	0	27	73
Kazakhstan	0	0	100
Uzbekistan	1	92	7
Georgia	0	56	44
Armenia	43	46	11
Belarus	0	10	90
Azerbaijan	0	74	26
Kyrgyzstan	0	84	16
Turkmenistan	0	100	0
Tajikistan	0	83	17
Post-Soviet unspecified	0	83	17
Moldova	0	0	100
<i>Post-Soviet, average</i>	5	50	45

Representation of East Central European countries in American, British, and Canadian films, %

	Positive	Neutral	Negative
Czech Republic	0	62	38
Hungary	32	7	61
Romania	0	18	82
Poland	69	20	11
Slovakia	89	1	10
Bulgaria	70	1	29
<i>East Central European, average</i>	43	20	37

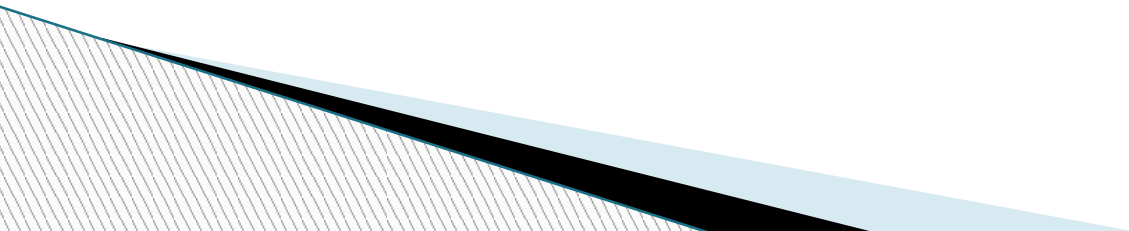
Post-Soviet vs. East Central European countries

- ▶ Post-Soviet countries have generally more negative representation than East Central European countries
 - Mostly negative representation of Russia, Ukraine, Belarus, Kazakhstan, and Moldova
 - Mostly positive representation of Poland, Slovakia, and Bulgaria
 - Exceptions: Armenia, Romania, Hungary
- ▶ Post-Soviet countries are generally depicted in less films and less popular ones than comparable East Central European countries
 - Exceptions: Russia and Ukraine

Representation of Russia in American, British, and Canadian films, %

Heroes/subjects	Percent	Content
Criminals/"Russian mafia"	25	Negative
The Soviet Union as Russia	15	Negative
Science/technology	7	Positive
Villains/vampires/monsters	7	Negative
Immigrants	7	Negative
Terrorists	7	Negative
Spies/Security services	5	Negative
Space	5	Negative
Cooperation with the West	4	Positive
WMD/Proliferation	2	Negative
Police	2	Negative
Adversary of the West	2	Negative
Russian Roulette	2	Negative
Military/Chechnya war	2	Negative
WW2/Holocaust	2	Positive
Other	4	Neutral
Total, %	100	

Representation of Ukraine in American, British, and Canadian films, %



Representation of Poland in American, British, and Canadian films, %

Heroes/subjects	Percent	Content
Immigrants	65	Positive
World War II/Holocaust	19	Neutral
Military	5	Positive
Criminals in the US	4	Negative
Communism/Iron Curtain	4	Negative
Villains/monsters/vampires	2	Negative
Location	1	Neutral
Sport/sportsmen	0.5	Negative
Total, %	100	

Allies vs. non Allies

- ▶ NATO members generally receive more positive representation than non-members
- ▶ Change in representation since NATO membership
 - Relatively more positive: The Czech Republic, Poland, and Bulgaria
 - Relatively more negative or not much change: Hungary, Slovakia, and Romania
- ▶ Change in representation after pro-Western “color revolutions”
 - Relatively more positive: Ukraine
 - Relatively more negative: Georgia

British & Canadian vs. American Films

- ▶ Representation of Post-Soviet countries is relatively more balanced in Canadian films
 - Due to two films dealing with Russia and co-produced with the US
 - *2012*
 - *Along Came a Spider*
- ▶ Representation of East Central European countries in Canadian films is less balanced
 - But only 4 films (3 joint with the US)
- ▶ Representation of post-Soviet countries in British films is less balanced than in American films

Representation of post-communist countries in American, British, and Canadian films, %

	Canada		UK		US	
	Post-Soviet	East Central Europe	Post-Soviet	East Central Europe	Post-Soviet	East Central Europe
Positive	27	0	3	28	11	29
Neutral	13	6	26	43	24	32
Negative	61	94	71	29	64	40
Total, %	100	100	100	100	100	100
Box office, million US\$	1113	111	6313	1726	25312	7291

Conclusions

- ▶ Post-Soviet countries have generally more negative representation than East Central European countries
- ▶ Post-Soviet countries with exceptions of Russia and Ukraine are depicted in less films and in less popular films than comparable East Central European countries
- ▶ NATO members generally receive more positive representation than non-members
 - Mixed results concerning change in representation

Implications

- ▶ Effect on public perceptions in Canada, the UK, and the US
 - Potentially sizable effect: The combined movie theaters audience for Ukraine-related films is close to the combined adult population of Canada, the UK, and the US
 - The negative representation of post-Soviet countries is likely to have greater effect compared to East Central European countries
 - Post-Soviet countries and the Soviet Union are often represented as Russia
 - E.g. Chornobyl/Chernobyl in at least 3 out of 8 films
 - Criminals, spies, and terrorists dominate negative representation of Belarus (82%), Russia (37%), & Ukraine (33%)
 - Mostly misrepresentation
 - Vampires and monsters dominate negative representation of Romania (64%) and Hungary (34%)